

result, spinal blocks are usually reserved for use during a cesarean, or for an assisted delivery when an epidural isn't in place.

Combined spinal epidural (CSE) or “walking epidural”

This involves both a spinal injection and putting an epidural in place. It's sometimes done when problems are encountered with an epidural (see [here](#)) and for a Cesarean. A CSE gives pain relief for about two hours, but additional medication can be put into the epidural so that it lasts as long as necessary. However, it's a specialized technique and isn't offered in all units.

Pudendal blocks

This type of regional anesthesia involves injecting a local anesthetic into the vagina where the pudendal nerves are located to reduce pain in the vagina and perineum. The pudendal needle is quite long and thick, so before the injection is given, a cold anesthetic spray is applied to the area. The anesthetic has no effect on the baby and can be used with other medications. It takes effect very quickly and is sometimes used just before birth to aid an assisted forceps delivery.

General anesthesia

Most cesareans are conducted using regional anesthesia. However, in some cases general anesthesia, where the mother is put to sleep, is necessary. This may be because of a failure of regional anesthesia, blood-clotting problems in the mother, an infection in the mother's bloodstream, or persistent fetal distress.

The procedure Precautions are taken to minimize the risks to you and your baby. You'll be given an antacid to reduce stomach acid. A urinary catheter will be inserted into the bladder and antiseptic applied to the abdomen before you're put to sleep to minimize the baby's exposure to the anesthetic.

As the mother is put to sleep, a face mask is held tightly over her nose and mouth. Because a major risk during general anesthesia is undigested food or liquids in the stomach reentering the mouth and going into the lungs (which can cause damage), you'll likely be told not to eat or drink anything once labor begins (because labor usually slows digestion), in case you need general anesthesia. You may be able to have ice chips, though. Once asleep, an anesthesiologist inserts a tube through your mouth and down your throat so that oxygen can easily reach your lungs. You may therefore have a sore throat when you wake up.

During the surgery the anesthesiologist cares for the mother, giving painkillers and anti-nausea medicine when needed. If you need general anesthesia for your Cesarean, your partner will not be able to be present in the operative room due to how rapidly everyone is working to help deliver your baby in a safe manner. However, your partner may be invited in after delivery to be present with your baby as the remainder of your surgery is finished.

After the surgery The procedure takes about an hour. The mother is woken shortly after the surgery is completed. The baby will typically stay with your partner until you have recovered enough from anesthesia to safely hold them. Since general anesthesia doesn't give localized pain relief, it's normal to need pain relief afterward. Morphine-based medication may be given for a day or two.

AN EPIDURAL “HEADACHE”
